

Chapter 166-1

After Liang Shi spoke, she realized she had misspoken. Her expression turned awkward.

Lu Jiayi, however, showed no reaction. Even though she could tell Liang Shi was deliberately being confrontational, she still smiled faintly. "Hard to say."

Because they weren't close, it was hard to say whether not seeing each other for a long time was good or bad.

She deflected the sharpness in Liang Shi's words.

For a moment, it made Liang Shi seem somewhat petty.

Liang Shi had always been rather smooth when it came to dealing with people, yet she didn't know why she harbored such hostility toward Lu Jiayi.

Looking at her just made her feel annoyed.

Actually, thinking about it carefully, Lu Jiayi hadn't done anything to make her dislike her.

It was just that in her mind, there was a "conceptual Lu Jiayi"—a fictional image that had already been colored by subjective impressions before she had even met the real Lu Jiayi.

It was rather unfair to Lu Jiayi.

Liang Shi seemed to be condemning her for things that hadn't happened, which was biased.

After thinking this, Liang Shi felt even more embarrassed. But then she thought again—she and Lu Jiayi were never meant to be the kind of people who could sit down together for a friendly cup of coffee. It was best to remain strangers.

Liang Shi's thoughts changed several times within a few minutes.

Before she could fully sort things out, Lu Jiayi suddenly asked, "Have you eaten?"

Liang Shi frowned. "Breakfast or lunch?"

Lu Jiayi chuckled softly at this. "Lunch."

"Not yet," Liang Shi said. "Why?"

"I'd like to treat you to a meal. Are you free?" Lu Jiayi paused after saying this, then added, "My business partner's wife."

Liang Shi: "..."

Chapter 166-2

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In the end, Liang Shi agreed.

For someone like Lu Jiayi, even if you couldn't be friends with her, it was best not to make her an enemy.

Plus, she was now Xu Qingzhu's business partner.

When Lu Jiayi called her that, she was probably reminding Liang Shi.

They were purely business partners, and there would be future dealings between them. The goodwill extended to Liang Shi was essentially "love the house, love the crow."¹

If she really declined, it would make Liang Shi seem ungrateful and could also affect Lu Jiayi's cooperation with Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi didn't want her own emotions to affect Xu Qingzhu.

The place they went to was a roast duck restaurant—a location Liang Shi had specifically chosen.

Considering that Lu Jiayi was from the capital, she chose a restaurant that was known for doing capital-style cuisine well. It was a way of catering to her preferences.

After the roast duck arrived, Lu Jiayi elegantly put on gloves, personally rolled one up, and then handed it to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi: "?"

"You eat it," Liang Shi said. "I can do it myself."

"Consider it my apology to you," Lu Jiayi said.

Liang Shi's brow furrowed slightly. "Did you do something wrong?"

"I'd like to know what I did wrong too." Lu Jiayi placed the rolled duck on Liang Shi's plate, then continued rolling with her head lowered, her voice also low. "Maybe I was just born with a face that people don't like?"

There was a hint of self-deprecation in her words.

Liang Shi was taken aback.

But she had to admit, Lu Jiayi's duck rolls really were beautifully made.

While Liang Shi was thinking about how to answer her question, Lu Jiayi had already changed the subject. "What made you think of coming here for roast duck? Did you investigate me in private?"

"Why would I investigate you?" Liang Shi ate the duck roll she had made, and only after swallowing did she say, "Your accent is very obvious."

Lu Jiayi: "I see."

This meal wasn't exactly comfortable for either of them, but at least Liang Shi was full.

When it came time to pay, Lu Jiayi was one step ahead. When the cashier handed the card back, Lu Jiayi raised it with a wave. "Consider it me trying to please my business partner."

Liang Shi was momentarily speechless.

Lu Jiayi seemed to really like the term "business partner." She always used it when mentioning Xu Qingzhu.

After the meal, Liang Shi was about to leave when she heard Lu Jiayi say, "Do you have anything to do this afternoon? There's a shooting range nearby. Want to go play?"

Liang Shi didn't understand her intentions, but under her sincere gaze, she slowly nodded.

Shooting was one of Liang Shi's hobbies and also a way for her to relieve stress.

She usually went to shooting ranges on her own, but since coming here, she hadn't had time to go.

When she and Lu Jiayi stood together, Lu Jiayi suddenly asked, "Want to compete?"

Liang Shi: "Compete in what?"

"Shooting, of course." Lu Jiayi laughed. "How are you so adorably clueless?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi had been called clueless before, but perhaps because of her good looks, people would add "adorably" when calling her that, making it sound friendly.

But here, "adorably clueless" wasn't commonly used to describe Alphas.

Still, Liang Shi didn't dwell on it. She raised her arm, held the gun in a standard posture, aimed at the bullseye, and pulled the trigger without warning.

Even with the silencer, you could still hear the sound of the bullet cutting through the air.

"Thud!"

Nine rings.

Lu Jiayi curved her lips. "Not bad."

She then turned to face her own target.

—Ten rings.

Afterward, Liang Shi also hit several ten-ring shots, but she wasn't as good as Lu Jiayi.

Lu Jiayi hit the bullseye almost every time.

It was just that her preparation time was very long—it took her twice as long as Liang Shi to take each shot.

In the end, naturally, Lu Jiayi won.

The continuous shooting made Liang Shi's palms a bit numb. She shook out her hands and admitted defeat graciously. "I lost."

Then she put down the gun and went to the rest area nearby.

Lu Jiayi followed. When she came over, she handed Liang Shi a bottle of water. After taking a few sips and screwing the cap back on, Liang Shi asked, "What do you want? Go ahead and say it."

"Can you satisfy anything?" Lu Jiayi asked in return.

"Not Xu Qingzhu," Liang Shi said.

Lu Jiayi: "..."

After a moment, Lu Jiayi leaned back in the lounge chair and laughed. "This is the first time I've seen someone make a bet without determining the stakes beforehand."

Liang Shi looked at her. "This is my first time making this kind of bet too."

"Aren't you afraid I'll make some unreasonable demand?"

"Why should I be afraid?"

"Oh?"

Liang Shi paused, then shrugged indifferently. "You can make any request you want. Whether I do it or not is up to me."

Hearing this, Lu Jiayi nodded slowly. "Interesting."

The atmosphere fell into silence.

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1. "爱屋及乌" (ài wū jí wū): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "love the house, love the crow (on its roof)." It means that when you love someone, you extend that love to everything associated with them. ↵

Chapter 166-3

After a moment, Liang Shi got straight to the point. "Go ahead and say it. What do you want to tell me? You didn't just want to go shooting with me, did you?"

Lu Jiayi snapped her fingers. "It's nice dealing with smart people."

"Don't." Liang Shi stopped her. "I'm not your business partner. You don't need to butter me up."

"You could always whisper in her ear at night." Lu Jiayi teased ambiguously.

Liang Shi was momentarily at a loss for words.

But Lu Jiayi restrained her smile and became more serious before getting to the point. "I had a question I wanted to ask before, but now I feel like I've caught a glimpse of the answer. Still, I want to ask it directly."

Liang Shi: "...Go ahead."

"You seem to really dislike me." Lu Jiayi said, "Ever since we first met. Can I ask why?"

She was very sincere—from her tone to her smile, everything was impeccable.

Most people seeing her like this would probably think they themselves had done something wrong to cause the current situation.

But Liang Shi stared at her for a while, then suddenly said, "Because you're too perfect."

Lu Jiayi's expression froze for a few seconds. Before she could squeeze out a smile, she heard Liang Shi continue, "You can do everything, and you do everything well. You're like a... mannequin. Too deliberate."

Lu Jiayi paused, somewhat at a loss for words.

She didn't know how to respond.

After a while, she finally said, "But in my view, Xu Qingzhu is also very perfect. She has no flaws, doesn't she?"

"She does," Liang Shi said.

Lu Jiayi: "?"

Liang Shi paused. "She can't cook, and her personality is a bit dull."

Lu Jiayi shook her head. "Those don't count as flaws."

"But you don't even have these flaws that don't count as flaws." Liang Shi said, "You seem to be able to do everything, always scheming and strategizing. I don't like people like you, because when I'm too close to you, I feel like I'm just a piece on your chessboard."

Lu Jiayi: "..."

After a long while, Lu Jiayi suddenly laughed, chuckling softly. "You're right."

"But whether I like you or not isn't important." Liang Shi said, "Have you never been disliked by anyone your whole life? Why do you need to find an answer from someone? Besides, I'm only unfriendly toward you—it hasn't reached the level of dislike."

Lu Jiayi replied, "Because I greatly admire my business partner. The people she values, I will also value."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi truly didn't understand the ways of business, but faced with Lu Jiayi's attitude, she didn't know whether to praise her professionalism or think this person was fake.

Lu Jiayi didn't take it to heart and explained on her own, "I guessed you were angry because I rescued Xu Qingzhu before you did, but I didn't expect the real reason to be this."

Liang Shi: "...Am I being petty?"

Lu Jiayi shook her head. "I admire you."

Liang Shi didn't understand. "Why?"

"You're very sincere." Lu Jiayi said, "It's been a long time since anyone has spoken to me like this. Although it sounds annoying, it's... the truth."

Liang Shi lightly pressed her lips together, then suddenly asked, "Don't you get tired of living with a mask on all the time?"

Lu Jiayi's expression shifted slightly, then she put on that faint smile again and changed the subject. "I'm getting engaged, so I need to go back to the capital tomorrow. Please pass a message to Xu Qingzhu for me—I'll be gone for about a week."

"Engaged?!" Liang Shi was shocked.

"What?" Lu Jiayi asked. "Only you two can get married early, but I can't get engaged?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"This is so sudden," Liang Shi said.

Lu Jiayi pressed her lips together. "It's arranged by my family. I expect... life won't be peaceful afterward."

"Then... will you still come back?" Liang Shi asked.

Lu Jiayi nodded. "Of course. After the engagement, I'll handle some things in the capital and then come back."

"I wish you well."

"Thank you."

As they were about to leave, Liang Shi suddenly asked, "So what kind of person is your fiancée?"

Lu Jiayi pressed her temples. "I haven't met her yet. I'll tell you after I've seen her. But I've heard she's..."

She paused briefly, struggling to think of an appropriate adjective. "A knockoff Medusa."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi never expected that after the world timeline had been changed, Lu Jiayi's life had completely shifted direction.

And Lu Jiayi told her this not because she wanted to win more of her favor, but because she cared a great deal about Xu Qingzhu as a business partner. The engagement was the same.

For once, Lu Jiayi didn't hide anything and told Liang Shi directly, "I can tell you're jealous. So if my engagement can dispel your wariness and jealousy and allow my cooperation with Xu Qingzhu to proceed more smoothly, I'm happy to do it."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Why are you telling me this?" Liang Shi asked.

Lu Jiayi paused, then smiled. "Because your wife cares a lot about your feelings."

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This meeting changed Liang Shi's view of Lu Jiayi somewhat.

Only a little bit, though.

Still, the news of Lu Jiayi's engagement surprised her, but she could understand it afterward.

Liang Shi drove home. That evening, just as she was about to go out to pick up Xu Qingzhu, she received a call from Chen Mian.

It was noisy on Chen Mian's end. The heavy metal music was so loud it made Liang Shi's ears hurt, and she quickly held the phone away.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked. "Where are you?"

"Four Colors Dusk." Chen Mian gave the name of a bar. "Come over."

Liang Shi asked, "Are you drunk?"

Chen Mian paused briefly. "It's not me. It's your sister."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Then take her to your place first, or somewhere safe. I'll come pick her up in about fifty minutes." Liang Shi said, "Is that okay?"

Most people wouldn't refuse such a request, so Liang Shi was about to hang up. But then she heard Chen Mian hesitate for two seconds on the other end: "No."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Do you have something to do?" Liang Shi said. "If that's the case, I'll go now..."

"No." Chen Mian said, "But I'm not suitable to be with her right now. I think... she needs you right now."

Liang Shi suddenly became alert. "What happened between you two? What's wrong with her?"

Chen Mian gave her an ultimatum. "You have twenty minutes."

Then she hung up.

Liang Shi: "..."